

HISTORY HAS A NASTY HABIT OF REPEATING ITSELF IN PAKISTAN. The sarcastic wit of well-known poet Salman Pirzada summed up the situation as the results of General Election 2024 came in. In a Facebook post, he quipped in Urdu, "The oppressors did such blatant rigging that it reminded me of the 2018 elections." On the one hand, he was referring to the outrage of the supporters of incarcerated former prime minister Imran Khan, whose Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) party-backed candidates won the highest number of seats at the federal level but who were also crying foul that many results were manipulated to deny the PTI a majority. On the other, Pirzada was citing the nearly identical situation in the previous general election in 2018, when other parties had levelled similar allegations of electoral manipulation that had allowed Imran Khan to come to power by the slimmest of margins.

On the face of it, both allegations seem to carry weight. As in 2018, this time, too, there are many seats where the final tally of votes represented a complete reversal of what initial counts suggested. The only difference is that, in 2018, the PTI had been the happy beneficiary, while in 2024, it has borne the brunt, with the anti-PTI parties—primarily former premier Nawaz Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N), the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) and the urban Sindh-based Muttahida Qaumi Movement (MQM)—being the beneficiaries. The target of the allegations both times has been the 'Establishment', Pakistan's euphemism for the military.

There was also a historic role reversal. The former Pakistan cricket captain had been ousted in April 2022, after he had fallen out with the very Establishment that had propelled him to the PM's post in 2018. Khan has been under arrest since May 2023, and had received prison

ELECTION 2024
A FRAGMENTED POLITY

PAKISTAN NATIONAL ASSEMBLY: A PRIMER

- The National Assembly of Pakistan, its lower house of Parliament, has 336 seats in all, with 266 general/ electable seats that go to the polls. A party needs to win 134 general seats to form government. The general seats are divided amongst the four provinces: Punjab (141 seats), Sindh (61), Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (45) and Balochistan (16). Islamabad has three seats
- In addition to these, there are 60 nominated seats for women and 10 nominated seats for minorities
- Nominated seats are allocated to parties based on their proportional strength within the 266 general seats
- A party gets one seat for women for every 3.5 general seats won
- Minority seats are allocated to different provinces based on their respective minority proportions

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY